

TITLE: SOCIAL MEDIA USE BY EMPLOYEES

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COMMITMENT TO INDIGENOUS RIGHTS, HUMAN RIGHTS, AND EQUITY

The District recognizes its responsibility to ensure that this procedure and the associated work promotes and protects Indigenous rights, human rights and equity. The District will strive to address and eliminate discrimination and structural and systemic barriers for students, staff, and community.

1.0 RATIONALE

To provide standards for the use of Social Media accounts while in the OCDSB environment.

2.0 DEFINITIONS

Please refer to Appendix A for a list of definitions of terms used in this procedure.

3.0 RESPONSIBILITY

- 3.1 Business and Learning Technologies is responsible for restricting access to Social Media platforms and providing support to staff to maintain the security of District Social Media accounts.
- 3.2 The Communications department is responsible for the management of all District Social Media accounts, providing guidelines on the use of Social Media accounts for schools, and managing all communications through Social Media in times of crisis or emergencies.
- 3.3 Principals are responsible for the management of their school's Social Media accounts.
- 3.4 Employees are responsible for complying with this procedure and with the Social Media guidelines of their professional college or association where applicable.

4.0 PROCEDURES

Application and Scope

- 4.1 This procedure applies to staff use of and access to Social Media platforms, blogs, personal websites, RSS feeds, and postings on other interactive sites, instant messaging applications, websites, and elsewhere on the Internet, for both personal and professional use.

General

- 4.2 Employees are encouraged to separate their personal and professional use of Social Media platforms but must maintain a sense of professionalism at all times, in their personal and professional Social Media use.
- 4.3 Principals, supervisors, or designates may monitor the public use of Social Media by their employees.
- 4.4 Staff are encouraged to contact their principal or the OCDSB Communications Department should they have questions about whether it is appropriate to post about certain kinds of material.

Use of Personal and District Social Media Accounts

- 4.5 Personal websites and comments not related to the OCDSB will clearly state that staff are not representing the views of the school, department, District, or Board. Notwithstanding this disclosure, such a disclosure does not absolve an employee from adhering to this procedure or from potential consequences for non-compliant posts or comments.
- 4.6 Employees will:
- a) interact knowledgeably and responsibly via Social Media while modeling mature and appropriate digital citizenship in accordance with District values, policies, and procedures;
 - b) refrain from engaging in online behaviour or posting comments that are defamatory and/or reflect negatively on the reputation of a student, employee, school, the District, or the Board;
 - c) refrain from posting harmful images or videos, or making slanderous comments, disclosing personal or confidential information about the school, students or colleagues, harassing others and/or inciting hatred against an individual or identifiable group; and
 - d) respect copyright laws, not only with respect to the content produced on Social Media but also to the software that enables it.
- 4.7 Staff will not accept “friend” and/or “follow” invitations from students on personal social media accounts or on school-based accounts, except where the account is related to a school course or school club and at least one other staff member has administrative access to the Social Media account.

Use of District-Approved Social Media Platforms and Accounts/Groups

- 4.8 The District authorizes and limits the use of Social Media platforms through its networks in compliance with Policy [P.100.IT: Appropriate Use of Information Technology](#).

- 4.9 Employees will:
- a) only use Social Media platforms approved for use in the District;
 - b) use only their own names when participating in an online Social Media group for academic purposes; and
 - c) acknowledge that all information posted on District-approved platforms and accounts/groups is subject to the provisions of the [Municipal Freedom of Information and Protection of Privacy Act](#);
- 4.10 Principals or designates will:
- a) only approve school-based Social Media accounts/groups that include a staff member advisor and have at least two staff members with administrative privileges;
 - b) ensure that a new advisor is identified when a staff member advisor or staff member with administrative privileges leaves the school; and
 - c) ensure that all communications on school-sanctioned Social Media accounts/groups adhere to Policy P.125.SCO School District Code of Conduct. As such, the content will be apolitical, respectful, and non-discriminatory or -hate-based on grounds protected from discrimination under the OCDSB Policy P.147.GOV Human Rights.
- 4.11 Social Media profiles created using or referring to a Board email address will only be used for school, District, or Board related purposes. For school Social Media accounts the principal must use the school's generic email account to create the account.

Use of Social Media when Representing the District

- 4.12 Unless given written permission from a Principal or designate or supervisor, an employee is not authorized to use Social Media to speak on behalf of the school, department, the District, or the Board.
- 4.13 Board and school logos will not be used on Social Media without first obtaining permission from the school Principal or designate, supervisor, or Communications Department.
- 4.14 Account administrators will:
- a) maintain periodic cleanup of District Social Media accounts;
 - b) avoid maintaining an overactive or inactive District Social Media account;
 - c) repost information from the District Social Media accounts that are relevant to their school accounts (i.e. District-wide programs, events).

Staff-Student Online Correspondence

- 4.15 The District will provide approved messaging platforms and websites for the purpose of facilitating two-way communications with students and families.

- 4.16 Where appropriate, educators may use school-approved Social Media accounts to make school-related announcements.
- 4.17 Engaging in unauthorized two-way communications with students through personal or District Social Media accounts is not allowed.

District Response to Misuse

- 4.18 Account administrators may delete inappropriate messages, where feasible, and will inform the OCDSB Communications Department.
- 4.19 Employees may be disciplined if:
- a) they post electronic commentary, content, or images that are defamatory, pornographic, proprietary, harassing, discriminatory, hate-based, reveal personal information without consent, or create a negative work environment; and/or
 - b) their Social Media activity, whether personal or work-related, results in a disruption to the school or Board environment or negatively impacts the individual's ability to perform their duties.

5.0 APPENDICES

Appendix A: Procedure Definitions

6.0 REFERENCE DOCUMENTS

[The Education Act, 2000, ss. 170, 171, 307](#)

[Ontario Teaching Profession Act](#)

[Council of Ministers of Education Fair Dealing Guidelines](#)

Ontario College of Teachers' [Use of Electronic Communication and Social Media Guidelines](#)

OCDSB Policy [P.100.IT: Appropriate Use of Information Technology](#)

OCDSB Policy [P.125.SCO School District Code of Conduct](#)

OCDSB Policy [P.147.GOV Human Rights](#)

[Web Content Accessibility Guidelines \(WCAG\) 2.0](#)

Ontario College of Teachers [Use of Electronic Communication and Social Media Guidelines](#)

OCDSB [X\(Twitter\)](#) account

OCDSB [Facebook](#) account

OCDSB [Instagram](#) account

OCDSB [YouTube](#) account

OCDSB [LinkedIn](#) account

APPENDIX A: PROCEDURE DEFINITIONS

In this procedure,

Board means the Board of Trustees.

District means the Ottawa-Carleton District School Board.

Inappropriate message means a statement that is unsuitable or unacceptable, violent or hateful, for example, a negative statement by a staff member about any other staff member, student or Board official.

OCDSB Community means trustees, committee members, council members, staff members, students, parents/guardians/caregivers, permit holders, vendors, service providers, contractors, volunteers, visitors, and all other persons learning, working, or accessing services in the OCDSB environment.

OCDSB Environment means Board property, school buses, virtual learning and working environment, electronic media, school or work-authorized events or activities, in before- and after-school programs including co-curricular activities and field trips, and may include any other circumstances that may have an impact on the school or work climate.

Social Media means websites and/or applications that enable Users to create and share content and/or to participate in social networking.

User means any member of the OCDSB Community using personal or District Information Technology within the OCDSB Environment